The legislators could not bluff Shah easily. He had already got detailed constituency-wise profiles of the state done and had used the Sangh Parivar network to identify just who were the MLAs, MPs and local leaders who were actually working on the ground. Interestingly, in the two years when he was forced to live in Delhi because of his bail conditions, he would travel to different parts of UP on weekends to familiarize himself with the environment. ‘I think much before 2013, he had been given a sense that he was going to have to manage the UP elections for the BJP and was fully prepared for it,’ says Sheela Bhatt, a senior journalist who has interviewed Shah on several occasions.

By contrast, Madhusudhan Mistry, the Congress’s general secretary for Uttar Pradesh, who was also from Gujarat, did not even recognize some of the party’s twenty-eight MLAs from the state. ‘One of our MLAs once told Mistry in a party meeting that if you don’t know who I am, how will you fight an election!’ a senior Congress member told me. Mistry, with his jhola and faded kurtas, had been hand-picked by Rahul. Pitted against the dynamic Shah, neither he nor his party had a chance.

Shah knew that the key to success was in re-energizing the party workers. This is where his close ties with the RSS worked hugely in his favour. A core team of RSS pracharaks was deputed to work with him. From the moment he took charge in Lucknow, Shah tirelessly criss-crossed the state by road and rail, staying at the homes of party workers, often having simple meals of *saunf khichdi* and *chaas* (fennel rice and buttermilk) with them. By the beginning of 2014, he had already covered around seventy of UP’s eighty Lok Sabha constituencies. By the time the elections were over in May, Shah had touched all eighty constituencies, spent 142 nights over a span of eight months in UP’s villages and towns, and travelled more than 90,000 kilometres across the vast state. ‘The idea was to awaken the dormant party worker, to make them realize that this was a do-or-die election battle,’ says an aide.

Where Modi could easily relate to young English-speaking technocrats, Shah preferred to deal with loyal Sangh activists. Sunil Bansal, a forty-four-year-old ABVP (Akhil Bharatiya Vidya Parishad, the RSS’s student wing)